Calkins Law Firm

The first six months: plan and answers to your seven questions

Prepared for Brad Calkins · Prepared by Prem Chandra · 13 October 2026

Written against your files 00, 01 and 02, your 13 October message, and live Search Console and GA4 data for 13 July to 10 October 2026.

How to read the tags. Measured = read directly from data. Inferred = my reasoning from data, with a confidence level. Practice = standard practice I have not yet tested on your site. Same convention as the assessment.

The short version

The plan in one line: make every enquiry countable and the path to the phone work (month 1), wire the site so the M&A and dispute pages can rank (month 2), rewrite those pages for a first-time seller (month 3), then let the day-90 numbers decide where months 4 to 6 go.

Your seven questions, one line each

1	Google indexes your main number. The pool swaps numbers in visitors' browsers only. Your real NAP risk is the directories, not the pool.
2	Yes, buy CallRail Forms. One place for calls and forms is right. Two conditions: it must capture your existing forms, and someone at the firm tags every enquiry.
3	I own the tracking setup end to end. You do the things only an account owner can do: buying, access, test calls and Business Profile owner actions. The firm owns the tagging.
4	A one-page monthly report, built by me from CallRail and Search Console, with a sheet behind it. No dashboard.
5	Your developer applies the SiteGround changes, because they are WordPress plugin settings. I write the exact settings and check them afterwards.
6	Keep Speed Optimizer, with the three tracking scripts excluded. The harm I found is narrow; the rest of what it does is useful.
7	AEO is secondary as a workstream. Nearly everything that helps AI answers is already in the plan for other reasons, so I would not reorder anything around it or buy a tool for it yet.

The order, and why

When	What	Why it comes here
Month 1	Phones, broken links, compliance titles, tracking (CallRail pool and forms, GA4, Tag Manager, Speed Optimizer exclusions), intake tagging, directory corrections.	Compliance ships first under your rule, and every week of tracking started now is another week of clean data at day 90.

When	What	Why it comes here
Month 2	Categories, internal links into the M&A and dispute pages, attorney bylines and author markup, the succession page, plain-word fixes on the dispute articles.	Rewriting pages that nothing links to doesn't move them, so the structure has to come first.
Month 3	Sell, buy and M&A pages rewritten for a first-timer, with titles in his words. Day-90 review.	By now the pages have links pointing at them and tracking has 8 to 10 weeks of clean data.
Months 4–6	Refresh 4 articles a month from founder interviews, build out succession and estates, and start M&A referral links.	This is sized by what day 90 shows, and the money goes where the enquiries actually came from.

What the live data changed since my assessment

- **The sell page is further from page one than I told you.** Over the last 90 days Search Console has it at average position 26.7 for “selling a business attorney” (225 impressions, 0 clicks) and 16.5 for “business sale attorney.” The rank tracker's 5 to 9 comes from one Cleveland location, while Search Console averages every searcher. Calling it “close” was too strong, which makes months 2 and 3 matter more than I implied. [Measured, high]
- **Click loss is real, but the impression loss is partly a reporting change.** Clicks fell 76% year on year. Impressions fell 81%, but in September 2025 Google stopped serving 100 results per page to rank-tracking tools, and that change removed tracker-driven impressions from Search Console for most sites. So for any before-and-after we should compare clicks, not impressions. It also suggests your suspicion about four rank trackers inflating the older numbers was right. [Clicks measured; cause of impression drop inferred, medium]
- **Your file 01 changes the brief.** If the website is mainly where a referred owner checks you out, then what he sees when he searches the firm's or the founder's name matters as much as rankings. Month 1 now includes a review of exactly that.

1. Answers to your seven questions

1. With a number pool running, what does Google see when it crawls?

Your main number. A CallRail pool works through a script in the visitor's browser that replaces the number after the page loads, and only for the visits it is tracking. The number written into the page itself stays 440-273-3005. That covers the HTML Google indexes, the header text, the tel: links and your organisation markup. [Practice]

I will check rather than assume. After setup I'll run the homepage and one article through Search Console's URL Inspection, which shows the page as Googlebot rendered it, and confirm the main number is there. That happens before anything changes on the Business Profile.

Your map-pack position depends on the Business Profile and your directory listings, not the pool. Two recommendations:

- **Don't change the Business Profile's primary number in month 1.** The common setup puts a tracking number as primary and your main line as additional. But a phone edit sends the listing through Google's review. The profile is the asset that already works (#1 in the map for “business attorney chagrin falls ohio,” #2 for “business lawyer” from Geauga), and month 1 already changes a lot. Its website and appointment links already carry tracking tags (I can see gbp_website and gbp_appointment in Search Console), so website visits from the profile will be attributed as soon as the pool is live. Calls made straight from the profile's call button stay on your main line for now. I'd revisit this in month 3, once everything else is stable. [Tags measured; timing is my judgement]
- **Fix the directories to one name, one address, one number: 440-273-3005, never a tracking number.** This is the real NAP problem: three phone numbers and two addresses in circulation, two Justia profiles, and LawInfo saying “since 2020.” Martindale, Avvo, Nolo, Lawyers.com, LawInfo and FindLaw appear to belong to one network, so one correction route may fix several at once. [Ownership inferred, medium]

2. CallRail Forms at $50/month: worth it?

Yes. I agree with your reason, that the habit won't survive two systems, and there are two more:

- 40 to 50% of your form volume is spam, and an enquiry count means nothing until spam is separated out.
- Form enquiries then carry the same source and landing-page data as calls. That data is what the report in question 4 is built from.

On cost, the add-on is about $600 a year, and a single M&A matter is $20,000 to $30,000 on the founder's own figures.

Two conditions:

1. It has to capture your existing contact forms without rebuilding them in Beaver Builder. I'll confirm that inside your CallRail account before you pay.
2. Someone at the firm tags every enquiry (matter type, and worth having yes or no). Without the tag the tool records volume, not quality, and the “how many were worth having” line in your report is my guess instead of your answer.

Where I'd disagree with going further: don't switch on recording- or transcript-based auto-qualification to avoid the tagging. It moves matter details into more systems, and you've told me those are confidential from first contact. My CallRail user needs sources, landing pages and tags, not recordings or message text. If CallRail's roles can't hide those from me, I'll work from a monthly export with those columns removed.

3. Who owns the tracking setup?

I own the design, the configuration in each tool, the testing and keeping it working. You do what only an account owner can do. The developer does anything that touches WordPress.

Piece	Me	You / the firm	Developer
CallRail pool	Pool size and sources, swap target, GA4 integration, re-authorise the Business Profile integration, tags	Buy numbers and add-on; give me admin access; place test calls	—
GA4	Cut key events to two (enquiry form, qualified call); remove the "purchase" event and the $5,000 value; internal-traffic filter; Search Console link	Upgrade my access to Editor; send office, home and developer IP addresses	—
Tag Manager	Move every tag into it (GA4, CallRail, click-to-call and form events) and publish	Give me Publish access	Remove any hard-coded duplicates I list
Conversion events	Define and build them	Approve the definitions	—
Forms	Spec spam protection, the "How did you hear about us?" field and CallRail capture	Tag every enquiry	Implement in Beaver Builder
Phones on the site	Spec the header number; replacement list for 216-859-4302; crawl to confirm	Confirm 440-273-3005 forwards before the change	Header element; database search-and-replace
SiteGround plugin	Exact exclusion list; verify	—	Apply the settings

One request: you mentioned six documented call-tracking faults. If that list exists in writing, send it and I'll make sure each one is closed in weeks 1 and 2.

4. Reporting: what tool, and will you build it?

Yes, I'll build it. It will be one page, sent here at the start of each month, covering your four things:

Your question	What the page shows	Source
Enquiries by source	Calls and forms by source (organic, Business Profile, direct or brand, directories and referrals, other), with spam removed	CallRail
How many were worth having	Count by matter type: sell, buy, dispute, succession or estate, general business, not a fit	The firm's tags in CallRail
Which pages produced them	Landing page of every worth-having enquiry	CallRail plus GA4

Your question	What the page shows	Source
What changed	What shipped; movement on the money pages (clicks and positions for the sell, buy, dispute and succession pages, kept separate from definition-article traffic); anything broken; decisions needed	Search Console, my change log

A Google Sheet behind it holds one row per enquiry, so you can check any number. I agree with you on the dashboard: a dashboard would also take hours every month to maintain that are better spent on the site. The first report will cover a part month. The day-90 report is the first one with enough clean weeks to compare sources fairly.

"Worth having" needs your definition. My suggestion is a matter in M&A, disputes, succession or estates, or general business above a size you set, from someone who could hire the firm. Vendors, job seekers, spam and out-of-area consumers don't count.

5. SiteGround changes: you or me?

Strictly, your developer. Speed Optimizer is a WordPress plugin, so its settings fall under your rule that specification and execution are separate. I'll write the exact list: exclude the Tag Manager container, the Google tag and CallRail's swap script from JavaScript deferral and from JavaScript combination. Your developer applies it, which should take under half an hour. I then check from outside that the number swaps on first load without a scroll, GA4 real-time shows the visit, and a test call arrives with the right source. Anything at SiteGround account level (Site Tools) needs your login, but I don't expect to need it.

6. Keep Speed Optimizer, or is it doing more harm than good?

Keep it. The harm I found is narrow (tracking scripts held back) and the exclusions fix it. The rest of what it does, page caching, image compression and file minification, is worth having on a Beaver Builder site, which is heavy by nature. Page caching is compatible with call tracking because the swap happens in the browser after the cached page arrives. [Inferred, medium; I haven't seen the plugin's settings screen]

Two checks before I close this. First, that no second optimisation or caching plugin is active, because two layers fighting each other would be a reason to remove one. Second, the Core Web Vitals field data in Search Console before and after the exclusions. If excluding three scripts changes nothing measurable, we're done.

7. Where does AEO belong in the plan?

Secondary as a workstream. You asked me to say so if I thought it, and I do. Here's why:

- **As a click source it's small.** GA4 shows 22 AI-assistant sessions in the last 90 days, against 2,163 organic. [Measured]
- **Clicks undercount it, though.** An owner who asks ChatGPT which firms to talk to and then searches your name shows up as brand search or direct, not as AI. Clicks can't measure that. Your 20-prompt study can.
- **What moves AI answers here is already in the plan for other reasons:** attorney bylines and author markup (month 2), directory cleanup (months 1 and 2), plain answers to first-timer questions on the M&A pages (month 3) and the succession page (month 2). It costs nothing extra, and nothing gets reordered around it.

On your study: the gap holds, but it's smaller than 2.3× once like is compared with like.

Prompt framing	Firm questions	Lawyer questions	Gap
Plain questions (no “best” or “top”)	51.5% (10 prompts)	32.1% (3 prompts)	1.6×
“Best”, “top”, “highly regarded”	33.3% (3 prompts)	11.7% (4 prompts)	2.8×
All prompts (your headline)	**47.3%**	**20.4%**	**2.3×**

Four of the 7 “lawyer” prompts contain “best,” against 3 of the 13 “firm” prompts, and “best” questions lower presence for both. AI tools tend to answer “best” from ranking directories (Best Lawyers, Super Lawyers and Chambers are all in your domain list). The firm can't win those answers by publishing, and it can't use the word on its own site anyway. So authorship explains part of the gap and directory rankings explain the rest. Whether to pursue third-party rankings is the managing partner's decision, and I would not spend on it in these six months. [Split measured on your data; explanation inferred, medium]

On precision: every figure matches a prompt run about 26 times (73.1% = 19 of 26, 7.7% = 2 of 26). At that sample a single prompt can move 15 to 20 points by chance, so judge the group averages, not individual prompts. [Inferred, high]

Cheaper tracking: I'll re-run the same 20 prompts myself each quarter in ChatGPT, Google's AI results, Perplexity and Gemini, three runs each, logged in a sheet. That sits inside the monthly budget and needs no subscription. The method differs from Scrunch's, so the first re-run sets a new baseline and later runs compare against it. The first re-run is at the end of month 3, after the bylines have been live a few weeks, and the next in month 6.

Directory cleanup in the first 90 days: yes. It belongs there for the map pack and for the referred owner checking you out, and any AI benefit is a bonus. Your AI Overview finding (they appear on informational searches, never on hiring searches) fits the click loss on the definition articles. I'd leave those pages alone and not write more of them.

2. The plan, month by month

The plan is built against your definition of a win at 90 days: every enquiry has a recorded source, the conversion path works, there's a monthly count by matter type, and there's enough clean data to decide where the next dollar goes. Priority order is as you set it: M&A and substantial disputes first, succession and estates next, general business captured where it is cheap.

Assumptions I've made (say if any is wrong): M&A pages are not tied to Cleveland, since a seller will travel. Disputes are local to the east side and Geauga, which is the map pack's job. No Cleveland location pages. The succession page is a practice page, not an article, so it doesn't break your rule against new articles. If we start in late October, Thanksgiving and Christmas fall in weeks 6 to 10, so interviews and approvals may slow there. That's why the first founder interview is early in month 2.

Month 1 (weeks 1–4): count everything, fix the path, ship compliance

1. **Phone replacement, in your order.** The firm confirms 440-273-3005 forwards correctly. The developer then replaces 216-859-4302 in all 139 articles after a database backup, covering every format the number appears in, tel: links included. I crawl the site to confirm none are left. After that, the script fix so the pool can swap.
2. **Header number:** visible text and a tel: link, top right, on desktop and mobile, both swap-eligible.
3. **Broken paths:** the 35 file:/// “Contact us” links pointed at the contact page; /business-transactions/ 301-redirected to the M&A page; the departed employee's biography removed and redirected, and the departed employee's email address taken off the attorney page that still shows it.
4. **Compliance sheet:** the 45 titles and descriptions plus your §3 items (five non-lawyers titled “Attorney,” /cleveland/, /about-us/, the founder's biography). Each line is written once, so it is also the final search title. The managing partner approves the sheet, then the developer updates it.
5. **Tracking:** GA4 cleanup, all tags into Tag Manager, the Speed Optimizer exclusions, the CallRail pool, CallRail Forms with the GA4 integration, the Business Profile integration re-authorised, spam protection on the forms, and “How did you hear about us?” added to the form.
6. **Intake:** the tag list agreed with you (sell, buy, dispute, succession or estate, general business, not a fit, spam; worth having yes or no), and a one-page guide for whoever answers the phone, including asking every new caller how they heard about the firm. That question is the only way accountant and banker referrals ever show up in the data.
7. **Directory correction pack:** one sheet with the correct name, address, phone and short biography for each listing (Justia ×2, Martindale, Avvo, LawInfo, FindLaw, Nolo, Lawyers.com and any others I find). Submitted from the firm's logins.
8. **The “checking you out” review:** what a referred owner sees when he searches the firm's name and the founder's name: the Business Profile, reviews, directory listings, the biography and fees pages. Delivered as a short fix list.

Done when: test calls from organic, the Business Profile and direct arrive in CallRail with the right source; a crawl finds no dead number or file:/// link; the compliance sheet is approved and live; and the first part-month report has gone out.

Month 2 (weeks 5–8): wire the site so M&A and dispute pages can rank

1. **Categories:** classify all 220 posts into Selling a business, Buying a business, Disputes, Succession and estates, General business, and Reference (the definition articles). You approve the list; the developer bulk-assigns.

2. **Practice pages become the hubs.** The existing M&A, selling, buying, disputes and litigation pages each get a short “start here” list of their best articles. No new hub pages are built.
3. **Internal links:** the 40 priority articles from Appendix B of the assessment, M&A first and then disputes. Each links into its hub with plain anchor text, and each hub links back out. I produce the link map and the developer inserts the links.
4. **Attorney bylines:** the roughly 37 articles in the founder's voice move to his author profile. The rest go to whichever attorney the managing partner names, after that attorney has read them, because their name on an article is a representation. Author markup (education, admissions, links to the cleaned directory profiles) and organisation markup carrying the main number. No star-rating markup from directory reviews, since Google doesn't show self-serving review stars.
5. **Succession page:** built from one recorded founder interview of 45 to 60 minutes, covering what happens to the business if he dies, and how succession and a sale fit together. It's drafted in-house as your file 01 describes (or by me). I do the search edit and the §3 check, an attorney checks accuracy, and the managing partner approves.
6. **Disputes, cheap wins only:** “So, You've Been Sued?” and the breach-of-contract articles retitled in an owner's words (“being sued by another business,” “suing a business for breach of contract”), with their calls to action fixed and links to the business litigation page. They can also link to the contingency-fee page, if the managing partner wants that promoted. The breach-of-contract article drew 117 clicks in 90 days, more than any other non-brand page apart from the joint-venture article. [Measured]

Done when: every M&A and dispute article is in a category and links to its hub, bylines and author markup are live and validate cleanly in Google's Rich Results Test, and the succession page is live.

Month 3 (weeks 9–12): rewrite the money pages for a first-timer; day-90 review

1. **Sell, buy and M&A pages rewritten for the owner in your file 01.** They answer the questions he thinks are stupid: what a letter of intent is, whether an offer is fair, what a lawyer costs to sell a business, what happens after he signs. The firm's model is stated as fact and never as a comparison: a senior attorney does the work, and fees are stated up front if the managing partner approves publishing them. The source is a second founder interview.
2. **Titles in his words:** “sell my business,” not “mergers and acquisitions.”
3. **Business Profile:** services and description aligned to selling, buying, disputes and succession; decide on the tracking number as primary (question 1) now that everything else is stable.
4. **AI re-run:** the 20 prompts, a few weeks after bylines go live.
5. **Day-90 review, one document:** enquiries by source and matter type for the clean weeks, which pages produced them, what moved on the money pages, what a referred owner sees now, and my recommendation for months 4 to 6. That includes whether search is where your M&A clients come from, and saying so plainly if it isn't.

Months 4–6: default plan, adjusted by day 90

- **Content refresh, 4 articles a month:** M&A and succession articles already sitting around positions 8 to 20 for owner-language searches. Each is rewritten from interview material, bylined and linked into its hub. Four a month fits $1,500 if first drafts stay in-house; if you'd rather I draft, it's two a month at the same budget.
- **Succession and estates built out** (estate planning for business owners), linked from the sell page. “Before you sell” is the bridge between the two.

- **Referral-led M&A links.** The owner talks to his accountant, banker or broker before he talks to a lawyer, so the links worth having are from places those people read: Ohio CPA and business-broker groups, local chambers (Chagrin Valley, Geauga), and regional business press through the founder's commentary. This only starts if day 90 shows the M&A pages producing enquiries; otherwise the money follows where enquiries actually came from.
- **Quarterly AI re-run** in month 6; monthly reporting continues.
- **Paid search** stays off under your rule. If attribution works by day 90 it becomes a decision for you, outside this budget.

What I'm deliberately not doing in these six months

- National head terms (“M&A attorney,” “business lawyer”) and “lawsuit lawyer near me,” which is held by injury firms and directories.
- New definition articles, or editing the existing ones. They cost nothing to leave alone.
- The ZIP-code pages. That's the managing partner's call, and I'd leave them as they are.
- A general technical-audit warning list, and three of the four rank trackers. I'd keep one, set to both Chagrin Falls and Cleveland.

3. What I'd need you and the firm to do

You asked which parts you'd implement rather than me. Everything not listed here is mine to specify, configure, check or write.

You (Brad)

1. **Access:** GA4 Editor (I have read-only), Tag Manager Publish, CallRail admin, and Business Profile Manager (already coming).
2. **Purchases:** CallRail Forms and the pool numbers.
3. **Tests:** confirm 440-273-3005 forwards before the 139-article change, and place three test calls once the pool is live.
4. **IP addresses** for the office, your home and your father's, and the developer, for the GA4 filter.
5. **The six call-tracking faults,** if they're written down.
6. **Business Profile owner actions** wherever Google requires the owner rather than a manager.
7. **Directory corrections** submitted from the firm's logins using my pack.

The firm

- Ask “How did you hear about us?” on every new call, and tag every enquiry in CallRail within two working days.
- Founder interviews: one recorded 45 to 60 minute session in month 2 (succession) and one in month 3 (selling and buying), then roughly one a month.
- Managing partner: approvals (your 24 to 48 hours); which attorney's name goes on which articles; whether ratings and fee ranges appear on the site; the ZIP-code pages.

Your developer

- Every WordPress and Beaver Builder change, from my written specs. I never hand over a change without the exact text, URL or setting, and I check each one after it ships.

4. Budget: $1,500 a month

How I'd spend your $1,500 each month, and what I estimate your developer needs on top of it at $30 an hour:

Month	My work, out of $1,500	Developer (estimate)
1	Tracking and attribution $650 · conversion path and compliance $450 · directories and the checking-you-out review $200 · reporting and coordination $200	11–15 hrs (≈ $330–450)
2	Categories, link map and hubs $650 · bylines and markup $300 · succession page $300 · directory follow-through and tracking checks $100 · reporting $150	13–18 hrs (≈ $390–540)
3	Money pages $650 · finishing the structure work $250 · Business Profile and AI re-run $200 · day-90 review $400	5–8 hrs (≈ $150–240)
4–6	Refresh, 4 articles $800 · succession and estates or referral links $350 · reporting and tracking upkeep $350	4–6 hrs a month (≈ $120–180)

One thing to confirm: I've assumed your developer bills the firm directly, outside the $1,500. If the developer's hours should come out of it, my share drops to roughly $950 to $1,170 in months 1 and 2. If so, I'd slow the directory work and the link retrofit first and keep the tracking work whole, because tracking is what everything else gets judged by.

5. Live data behind this plan

Search Console and GA4, 13 July to 10 October 2026, compared with the same window in 2025 where shown.

Finding	Figure	Tag
Google clicks, year on year	1,437 vs 6,113 (−76%)	Measured, high
Google impressions, year on year	260,567 vs 1,375,122 (−81%); partly the September 2025 reporting change	Measured; cause inferred, medium
Sell page on “selling a business attorney”	Average position 26.7, 225 impressions, 0 clicks	Measured, high
Sell page on “business sale attorney”	Average position 16.5, 97 impressions, 0 clicks	Measured, high
Business Profile link on “business attorney near me”	Average position 1.1, 25 impressions; the homepage also shows at position 1 for a handful of “business litigation attorney” and “estate planning attorney” searches, which are map results near the office	Positions measured; map pack inferred, medium
Top non-brand pages by clicks	Joint-venture article 250; breach-of-contract article 117; LLC pros and cons 75	Measured, high
GA4 sessions from outside the US	52% (Singapore alone 1,132 sessions at one page per visit)	Measured, high
Direct vs organic sessions in GA4	2,967 vs 2,163; direct is inflated by the same bot traffic	Measured; cause inferred, medium
AI-assistant sessions	22	Measured, high
Business Profile links carry tracking tags	gbp_website and gbp_appointment both appear in Search Console	Measured, high

Next step. If you agree with the order, the first thing I need is the access in section 3, and week 1 starts when it's in. If you'd change any of this, now is a better time to tell me than month 3.